Hindu. [29] A similar phonetic shift survives in the modern Indian language of Assamese and is easy to master.

The texts are clear that the Avestan people came to Iran from outside. Unlike the Rig Vedic Indians, they are much more self-consciously an ethnic group and call themselves the Aryan people. This makes sense because they were the outsiders in a foreign land and would have wanted to differentiate themselves. Moreover, they are aware of Sapta-Sindhu but not of western Iran, suggesting that they entered the country from the east. Unlike the Vedas, the ancient Persians also talk of an original 'Aryan' homeland and even name the river Helmand in Afghanistan after the Saraswati (i.e. Harahvaiti). Indeed, the Persian identity as 'Aryans' was so strong that their country would come to be known as the Land of the Aryans or Iran. As recently as the late twentieth century, the Shah of Iran used the title 'Arya-mehr' or Jewel of the Aryans. Contrast this with the Indian identification with the Bharatas.

Another interesting indicator of the sequence of events is the use of the terms 'deva' and 'asura'. In the Rig Veda, the terms apply to different sets of deities and do not have *clear connotations* of good and bad. The god Varun, for instance, is described as an asura. However, in later Hinduism, the asuras would be identified as demons and the devas as the gods. In contrast, devas refers to demons in the Zoroastrian tradition of Persia while the word asura is transformed into Ahura Mazda—the Great Lord. [30] Since the deva–asura dichotomy is not clear cut in the Rig Veda but becomes very distinct in later texts, it is reasonable to argue that these opposing sets of meaning came to be attached at a later date. What caused this separation? Did the Parsu have a religious dispute with the Bharatas? As they moved into the Middle East, was the Persian nomenclature influenced by the Assyrian god called Assur? One may never know for sure but these are some more intriguing possibilities.

There is a lot more evidence of Vedic-related tribes in the Middle-East in the second millennium BC. In 1380 BC, the Hitties signed a treaty with a people called the Mittani. This treaty is solemnized in the name of Vedic